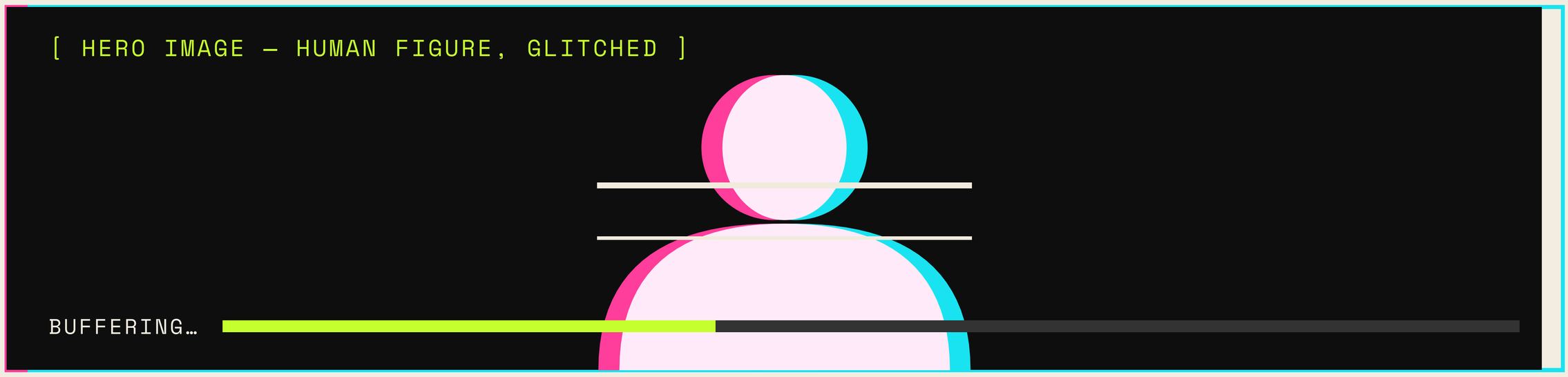
[SECTION / FEED] FEATURE LOADING 62%

WHERE ONE CLICK LEADS

WORDS
Lekhaa MeenakshiSundaram

READ
04 MIN

A single click can send you down an endless digital rabbit hole.



One search, four platforms.

“ONE ENCOUNTER CAN QUIETLY BECOME A TRAIL.”

NOTIFICATION now
Because you searched Endgame: more Marvel.

I didn’t go looking for Marvel but it still found me. It all began when I looked at BookMyShow, trying to find tickets for the Avengers: Endgame re-release. I wasn’t exactly looking for details about the entire Marvel Cinematic Universe. Somewhere between checking showtimes and scrolling past posters, Endgame appeared on my screen over and over again, dragging with it everything associated with it. Iron Man, Captain America, and Spider-Man popped up everywhere.

Once I booked my tickets, I put closed the app and put my phone down.

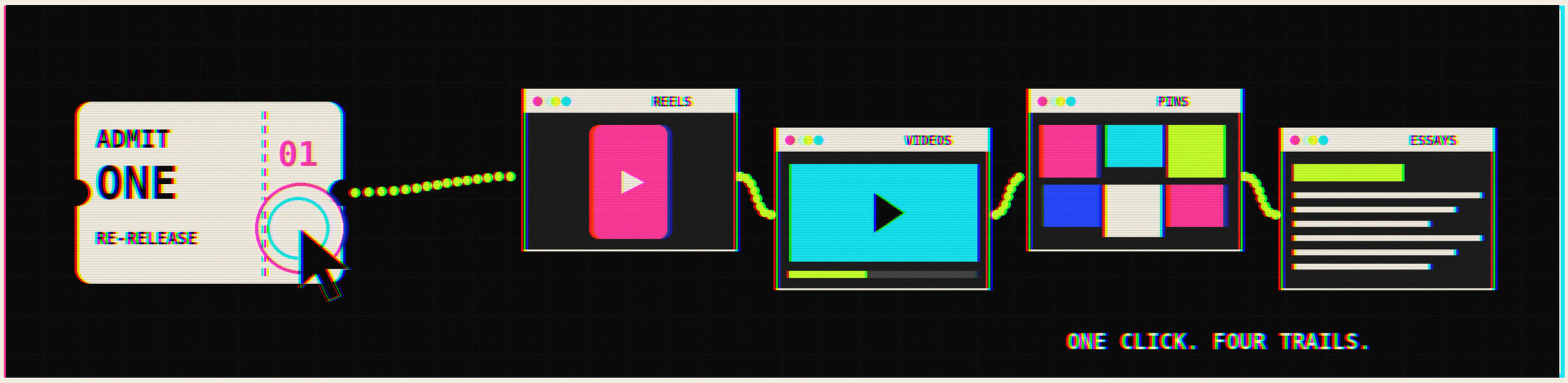
The next time I saw Marvel appeared, it was on Instagram. There was a reel about Avengers: Doomsday that showed up between the vampires and books. Then came another. Next was an edit using scenes from Endgame to speculate about what might happen in Doomsday. I had gone from looking for a ticket for a ticket to an old movie to being reminded that a new Avengers movie was on the way. YouTube followed the next day. I opened the app to watch an episode of my favorite childhood comfort show. Before I could type it into the search bar, I was flooded with shorts and fan theories about what was going to happen in Doomsday.

ERROR // Interest detected on four apps. It followed you.

At that point, I wondered if Marvel was following me.

The strangest part was that Marvel never appeared in quite the same way on different platforms. I often read articles on Substack. My feed is usually populated with personal essays by women about their experiences and their attempts to challenge patriarchal

[SECTION / FEED] PART 2 LOADING 88%



The same interest, in four languages.

NOTIFICATION now

Instagram: you might also like Doomsday.

“A SEARCH HERE, A PAUSE THERE, A CLICK SOMEWHERE ELSE.”

domination. I expected to see more of the same. Initially, that was what I found.

Then, it was as if someone whispered to Substack ‘show her Marvel.’ Moments later, I saw a guide of what someone had to watch in order to understand Doomsday. Now, I knew I wanted to watch it when it released and I was sucked into this post.

By then, I was convinced that Marvel was following me across apps. Curious to see where else it would turn up, I opened Pinterest. There was a tiny part of me that still hoped I’d find something other than Marvel. I ended up looking at fan-made posters, character edits, pictures of Doctor Doom and screenshots from Endgame.

On Instagram I’d been watching people speculate about Doomsday. On YouTube I had been listening to people explain those theories. On Pinterest I was seeing a physical manifestation of those theories.

None of these platforms was showing me exactly the same thing, yet their content was connected. It was almost as if each platform had its own language. Instagram gave me the speculation, YouTube the explanations, Pinterest the visuals, and Substack the longer discussions. The subject remained the same, but each platform offered a different way of engaging with it.

To be fair, I helped it travel too. I had searched for it on BookMyShow. Then I’d watched the reels on Instagram when they showed up. I probably paused on the videos on YouTube longer than I meant to. I read all the posts on Substack because I genuinely was interested in the movie. Each time I engaged with the content, I gave the platforms another reason to show me more of it.

I hadn’t consciously decided that I wanted to know more about the Avengers. Yet, the little things I did were adding up, signalling my interest and shaping what I would see next.

Now, this could have been about pretty much anything. A recipe I save on Instagram could lead me to a longer cooking video on YouTube, and then a Pinterest board full of variations of the same dish. A book I see on Instagram could become a review on YouTube and an essay about it on Substack. One encounter can quietly become a trail.

What makes it interesting is that the trail isn’t identical. We don’t see the same post copied five times. Instead, each platform gives us another piece of the thing. One shows us the object, another explains it, another interprets it, and another turns it into something visual. By the time we have moved through them all, we may know far more about something than we ever intended to.

That’s why it felt like Marvel was following me. It wasn’t one platform following me. It wasn’t one platform chasing me around. It was the same interest being recognised, picked up and passed along. I was carrying it too, without really noticing it. A search here, a pause there, a click somewhere else. They weren’t decisions on their own. Together, they told my phone that I had a decision.

I went looking for a ticket but ended up with an entire universe about the movie.